

**Machine-gun**

A fully automatic weapon intended for sustained fire from an ammunition belt or magazine.

Mainspring

The principal spring of a gunlock mechanism. In early gunlocks, it powered the wheel or cock, and in later mechanisms, the hammer, striker, or firing pin.

Magazine

A storage device, detachable or integral, in a gun for holding and feeding the ammunition. Forms include box, drum, or tube.

Magnum

A long version of a standard cartridge. Its increased length helps to accommodate more powder for higher velocity, power, and range.

Matchlock

A firing mechanism incorporating a match-cord (or “slow-match”) that ignites the priming powder when the trigger is pulled.

Match-cord

A hemp cord which was used to ignite gunpowder in early firearms.

Medium machine-gun

A machine-gun chambered for rifle-caliber ammunition and capable of sustained fire.

Metallic cartridge

A cartridge with a metallic case. Most are self-contained—propellant, projectile (bullet), and chemical primer are held within the case.

Miquelet

A type of flintlock mechanism—prevalent in the Mediterranean between the late-16th and mid-19th centuries—in which the mainspring is on the outside of the gun.

Mortar

A short-barreled, muzzle-loading artillery piece that fires projectiles at high angles. Mortars have evolved from weapons firing solid projectiles of stone to those firing special self-propelled explosive projectiles.

Musket

A smoothbore, muzzle-loading long arm that fires a spherical lead ball; the standard military weapon carried by infantry from the 16th to the mid-19th century.

Muzzle brake

A device that reduces the muzzle’s tendency to lift or swing. Also known as a compensator.

Muzzle-loader

A firearm in which the propellant and projectile are loaded from the gun’s muzzle.

Nipple

A small tube screwed into the breech of a percussion firearm’s barrel. It was hollow and allowed the burning gases from the primer to reach the breech.

Open frame

A revolver design in which the cylinder is not contained by a top-strap of metal and can be removed easily for cleaning.

Pan

The receptacle for holding the priming powder of either a matchlock, wheel-lock, or flintlock gun.

Parabellum

The 9 × 19mm cartridge developed by Georg Luger for his self-loading pistol.

Patchbox

A compartment in the stock of a firearm; used for storing tools and patches of greased cloth, in which the ball of a muzzle-loading rifle was wrapped before it was loaded in order to grip, clean, and lubricate the bore.

Pepperbox

A popular name for a type of revolver, usually percussion, which had no separate barrel. Instead the chambers of the cylinder were extended to form a group of barrels.

Percussion-cap mechanism

A firing mechanism featuring a small cap containing fulminate that serves as a primer.

Pin-fire

Describes a self-contained cartridge that includes a metal pin, which strikes and ignites the primer within the cartridge when hit by the weapon’s hammer.

Pistol

A nonrepeating, repeating, or semiautomatic small arm designed to be fired from one hand.

Pawl

A bump or a knob on the frame of a small arm to prevent the user’s hand from slipping.

Pricker

A pointed metal tool used to clean out residual gunpowder from a gun’s touchhole.

Primer

A substance lit by a firing mechanism to ignite the main charge in the barrel. Priming powder (gunpowder) and a detonating chemical, such as fulminate, are both examples of a primer.

Priming powder

The small amount of fine gunpowder lit by a firing mechanism to ignite the main charge in the barrel.

Projectile

A bullet, ball, grenade, or shot (group of small lead balls), fired by a firearm.

Propellant

The chemical substance, such as gunpowder, which imparts movement to the projectile in a firearm. Also called the main or powder charge.

Ramrod

A wooden or metal rod employed in charging the weapon by ramming the wad and bullet or shot down the barrel against the powder charge.

Recoil

The rearward movement of the barrel (or weapon) in reaction to the forward motion of the bullet.

Recoil operation

A type of firearm action in which the loading cycle is driven by the recoil of the barrel or breechblock after the firing of a cartridge.

Recoil spring

A coil spring attached to the slide or other type of breech component of a self-loading or automatic firearm. It initially absorbs the recoil, then returns the slide or breech mechanism to the closed position, readying the gun for firing.

Recuperator

A device that enables an artillery piece’s barrel to return to its firing position after recoil.

Repeating rifle

A rifle that can discharge multiple consecutive shots using cartridges loaded from a magazine.

Revolver

A gun that carries ammunition in a rotating cylinder.

Rifle

A long-barreled firearm with spiral grooves in the barrel.

Rifling

The spiral grooves cut into the barrel that induce spin on the bullet.

Rifled musket

A musket which has been rifled by adding grooves in its barrel to impart a spin to the bullet.

Rim-fire

Describes a self-contained cartridge that carries the primer in its rim. The primer is ignited when the firing pin strikes and crushes the rim when hit by the weapon’s hammer.

Safety catch

A mechanism which helps prevent the accidental discharge from a firearm, ensuring safe handling.

Sear

An often hooklike part of the firing mechanism that connects the trigger to the cock, hammer, or striker.

Selective fire

The system in some firearms for switching between semiautomatic and automatic firing mode. The preferred mode can be activated by means of a selector.

Self-loading

Describes a weapon that employs recoil force or the force of exploding propellant gases to eject a spent cartridge and chamber a new one. Also known as auto-loading.

Semiautomatic

Describes weapons that go through one cycle of firing and self-loading on each pull of the trigger, but do not perform continuous fire. Also known as self-loading. See also *Automatic*.

Serpentine

An S-shaped piece of metal with a central pivot attached to the side of a matchlock gun. It held a slow match that was lowered onto the priming pan on pulling the trigger.

Shot

A measured quantity of small lead pellets.

Shrapnel

Fragments or debris thrown out by an exploding shell, grenade, or bomb.

Single-action

An action type, typical of a revolver, in which the hammer must be cocked manually prior to each shot.

Silencer

A device that reduces, but rarely silences, the sound, flash, and recoil of a fired round.

Single-shot rifle

A rifle that has to be manually reloaded after every shot.

Slide action

A firearm mechanism in which the rearward and forward motion of a sliding sleeve ejects the spent cartridge case, loads a new cartridge, and cocks the gun. Also known as pump action.

Smokeless powder

A smokeless propellant, used almost universally now, that is composed of a mixture of nitrocellulose and other chemicals and is shaped into thin flakes before being loaded into a cartridge. Unlike black powder (gunpowder), it does not give away a concealed shooter’s position.

Smoothbore

Describes a gun barrel lacking a rifled interior.

Snaphance

An early flintlock mechanism featuring a separate pivoting striking surface made of steel, and a sliding pan-cover. Sometimes spelled “snaphaunce.”

Solid frame

A revolver design in which the cylinder is held in a rectangular frame made by the top and bottom straps, the standing breech end, and the part of the frame forming the rear of the barrel.

Stock

The portion of a firearm that is held by the person firing it.

Submachine-gun

A handheld, fully automatic weapon firing pistol-caliber rounds; it is shorter than a rifle.

Suppressor

Another word for silencer.

Toradar

An Indian matchlock gun on which the barrel and the stock are fastened together by coils of rawhide or wire.

Touchhole

A hole in the breech of early cannon and small arms through which the main charge was ignited. Also known as the vent.

Trigger guard

A frame protecting the trigger from damage and unintentional pressure that could accidentally discharge the weapon.

Trunnion

A cylindrical protrusion on each side of the barrel of an artillery piece on which it pivots to lower or elevate its barrel.

Under-lever

A lever, placed under the barrel near the trigger guard, that is used to open the breech in most lever-action guns.

Wad

A piece of paper, cardboard, or felt, used to retain the charge in the cartridge or barrel.

Wheel-lock

A firing mechanism that provided a means for self-igniting a firearm for the first time. It featured a wheel that created sparks on rubbing against a piece of iron pyrite. The sparks then lit the priming powder.